

Wild 2025

The Announced Return

Rewilding
Portugal



Wilder nature

Beavers have returned to Portugal, in a year when the connectivity of the Côa River has been widely discussed

Fire prevention

Rewilding and natural grazing have proven to be powerful allies in preventing and reducing the intensity of wildfires

Increasing engagement

The 2nd National Rewilding Symposium and the many documentary screenings broadened the narrative of rewilding in the country

Nature for people

The Wild Côa Network and nature tourism offerings in the Greater Côa Valley are gaining ground in the market



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Message from the Executive Director

Wild 2025 – The announced return

The year 2025 will be remembered as a turning point for nature in Portugal – and, in particular, for the Greater Côa Valley. It was a year of consolidation, but also of confirmation: when we give nature space, time and conditions, it responds.

The return of the beaver to Portuguese territory, more than five centuries after its disappearance, is perhaps the most powerful symbol of this movement to restore wildlife. It is not just the return of a species. It is the return of an ecological process. Beavers are ecosystem engineers, capable of restoring wetlands, increasing water retention in the landscape, creating refuges for countless species and strengthening the resilience of rivers in the face of drought and fire. Their return confirms something fundamental: ecosystems still have the capacity to regenerate if they are reconnected and protected.

But the beaver is not alone. In 2025, we reinforced herds of Sorraia horses, welcomed back Tauros to the Greater Côa Valley and continued to promote natural grazing as a central tool for ecological restoration. This work, based on mixed herds of large herbivores in a semi-wild regime, is not an abstract or theoretical experiment. It is a concrete, measurable effort, accompanied and monitored in the field.

In a context where Portugal is discussing the National Nature Restoration Plan, it is important to emphasise that restoration is not achieved solely through planting or one-off interventions. Above all, it is achieved through functional ecological processes. Natural grazing is one such process. By promoting mosaics of vegetation, reducing accumulated biomass and increasing landscape heterogeneity, these herds contribute to reducing the risk of fire, increasing biodiversity and improving the water retention capacity of soils. We are talking about hundreds of hectares under active management, with observable and replicable results.

What we do in the Greater Côa Valley can and should contribute to national and European restoration goals. We have data, continuous monitoring, scientific partnerships, and an adaptive approach that allows us to learn with each step. Restoration needs scale, but it also needs practical examples. Our territory is now one such example.

This effort is already being recognised in the region. Rewilding is no longer just an imported concept, but has become a local opportunity. In 2025, we trained new entrepreneurs,

strengthened the Wild Côa Network, and supported businesses linked to nature tourism, local production, and wildlife-related services. More visitors, more trained operators, more private rewilding initiatives all this shows that restoring nature is not a brake on development. On the contrary, it is a solid foundation for more resilient and diversified rural economies.

Even in the face of severe challenges, such as the fires that affected the region in the summer, it became clear that landscapes with active natural natural grazing responded differently. The lower and more irregular vegetation acted as a natural barrier to the spread of flames. At the same time, we mobilised direct support for local producers and partners, reinforcing the idea that rewilding integrates nature and communities, rather than separating them.

Recognition of our work has also crossed borders. The documentary “Côa Mais Selvagem” (Wilder Côa), which portrays this ongoing transformation, was broadcast on national television, reaching over a million viewers, and is now available online, allowing our work to reach new audiences inside and outside Portugal. The narrative of a territory that is committed to the recovery of natural processes, coexistence and ecological innovation is gaining momentum. This is fundamental: restoring nature also requires restoring the collective imagination about what is possible.

In 2025, we also held the 2nd National Rewilding Symposium, bringing together thousands of participants online and hundreds in person, confirming that the debate on the future of nature in Portugal is more alive than ever. Rewilding is no longer a peripheral issue. It is now an integral part of the discussion on climate, biodiversity, land use planning, and rural development.

The figures for the year – hectares managed, species recorded, visitors received, operators trained, new initiatives launched – reflect growth and consolidation. But more than numbers, they reflect confidence. Confidence from private landowners who entrust their land to rewilding processes. Confidence from entrepreneurs who invest in nature-related services. Confidence from citizens who support, visit and spread the word.

The return of the beaver reminds us that nature responds when it finds space. The challenge now is to ensure that this space exists – in rivers, in open landscapes, in political decisions and in the country’s strategic vision. The National Restoration Plan represents a historic opportunity. To be successful, it will need to integrate solutions based on natural processes, such as wild herbivory, river connectivity and the return of key species.

2025 was the year when several comebacks became reality. That of wildlife. That of hope. And that of a vision of a territory where nature and people thrive together.

It is up to us to continue.



PEDRO PRATA
Team Leader

Can we bring more nature back, please?



Former Director for Natural Capital at the European Commission’s DG Environment Humberto Delgado Rosa

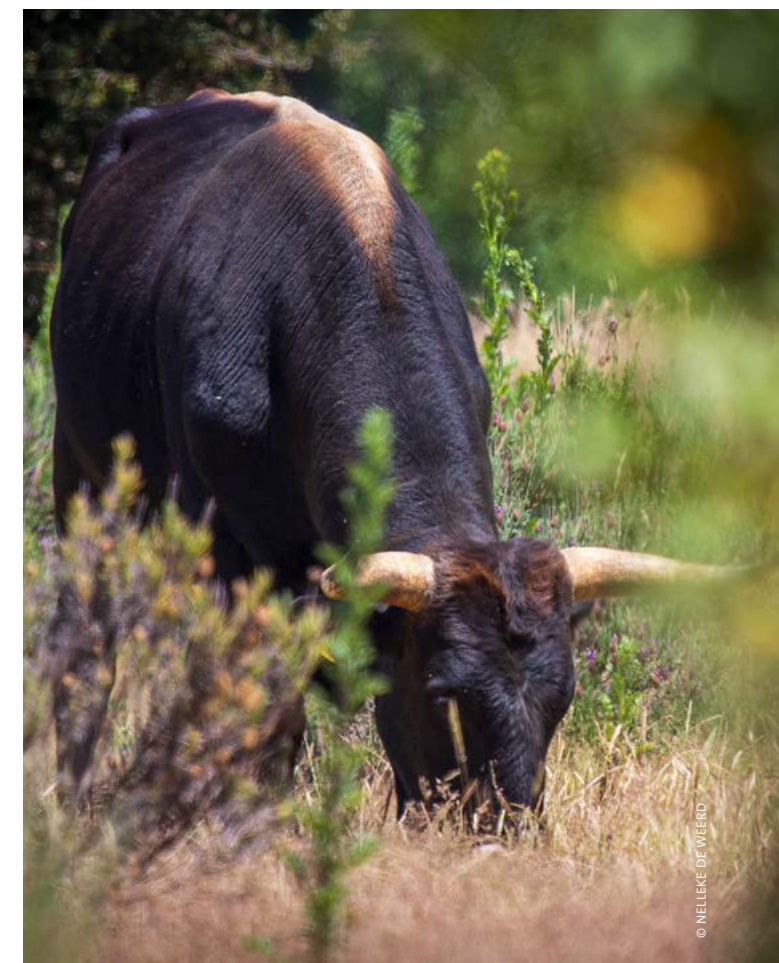
I am one of those people who were born with biophilia – a particular fondness for nature and animals. In my case, this had a profound influence on my academic and professional career. I was shocked to see the documentary “A Life on Our Planet” by the legendary David Attenborough, which reveals that since 1960, the year I was born, half of the planet’s nature has been lost. The feeling of generational failure that this left me with is only mitigated by the power of the word ‘restoration’: we can restore much of the lost nature and its ecosystem services on which we so depend.

Rewilding is certainly not the only approach to restoration, but it is one that I identify with. Many of today’s environmental problems, whether mega forest fires, catastrophic floods or soil degradation, are directly related to the excessive simplification of ecosystems that we have been carrying out throughout history. Rewilding has the proven potential to restore natural processes, reconnecting species, habitats and communities. It is less about returning to an ecological past and much more about opening up a future in which nature once again has more space for the benefit of all.

As part of Rewilding Portugal’s work, I have been pleased to see symbolic and historical restorations, including the return of iconic creatures such as European bison and aurochs. Alongside them, other species are recovering, whether it be roe deer repopulating valleys and clearings, or Iberian wolves with greater opportunities for expansion. I particularly like the way Rewilding Portugal strives to involve local communities, fostering coexistence, interacting with farmers and local agents, promoting new businesses and visitation.

Faia Brava, so closely linked to the origins of this movement, reminds me of when a new national nature conservation regulation I was involved in first established the concept of private protected areas. Faia Brava was a pioneer, and continues to be a beacon of conservation and restoration among us. It is one of the places where you can see the regeneration of native vegetation, the return of wildlife, the role of large herbivores in biomass management, helping to prevent large fires and fertilising the soil. Restoration is no longer just a technical concept, but has become very human and social, based on shared trust, learning and commitment.

Integration into Rewilding Europe has brought scale and international vision, amplifying local impact and connecting the Côa Valley to a European network of rewilding landscapes. The new Nature Restoration Regulation has set ambitious targets for Europe, and Rewilding Portugal is an example of solutions and willingness to help achieve them. Restoration and rewilding should set the pace for an era of reconnection between people and nature, in territories that can once again thrive on their own.



Rewilding Portugal

Rewilding Portugal is a private non-profit organisation founded in January 2019 that works to restore nature and bring wildlife back to the Greater Côa Valley. Based in the city of Guarda, it operates throughout this territory, one of the most important ecological corridors in Portugal, where it carries out rewilding actions aimed at recovering ecosystems, strengthening biodiversity and creating more resilient landscapes.

With a long-term vision, Rewilding Portugal seeks not only to regenerate nature, but also to boost more sustainable local economies based on the natural wealth of this extraordinary

valley. By promoting innovative activities linked to nature tourism, the promotion of local products and conservation, we are contributing as a local society to a more prosperous future for those who live and work here. As part of the European network of rewilding areas coordinated by Rewilding Europe, Rewilding Portugal works closely with various national and international partners. Together, we share a common goal: to make Portugal a wilder, more vibrant and biodiverse country.

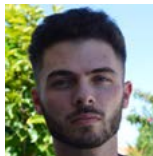
Team



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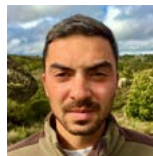
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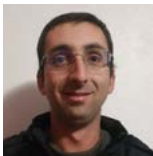
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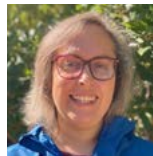
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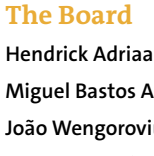
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Miguel Bastos Araújo
João Wengorovius Meneses
Maria do Rosário Gaspar de Oliveira
Graça Maria da Fonseca Caetano Gonçalves

The Board



DISCOVER OUR Touristic Packages



KNOW
MORE ON
OUR
WEBSITE



Rewilding Portugal in numbers

Rewilding ● Enterprise ● Communication ● Coexistence ●

2.442

HECTARES UNDER
MANAGEMENT BY
REWILDING PORTUGAL



3.487

NIGHTS IN THE REWILDING
CENTRE AND AT THE
BRIGADEIRO'S HOUSE



223

VERTEBRATE SPECIES
REGISTERED IN THE AREAS



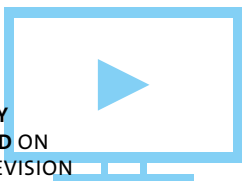
110

SPECIES OF FUNGI
REGISTERED IN THE AREAS



19

DOCUMENTARY
BROADCASTED ON
NATIONAL TELEVISION



54

WOLF-PROOF FENCES
INSTALLED



64

MEMBERS OF THE
WILD CÔA NETWORK



678

HECTARES UNDER GRAZING
WITH WILD HERBIVORES



27

ASSISTANCE PROVIDED
IN FIRES



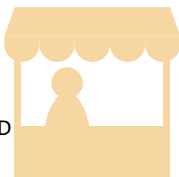
32M

MENTIONS OF US IN
THE NEWS IN 2025



13

13 FAIRS PARTICIPATED
IN DURING 2025



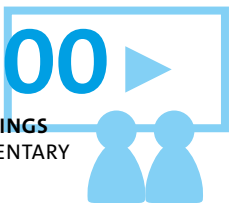
15

CINEREOUS VULTURE NESTS
CONFIRMED AND REMAINING
IN MALCATA



+3.000

PEOPLE IN VIEWINGS
OF THE DOCUMENTARY



12

BASKETS OF LOCAL
PRODUCTS DEVELOPED



18

MARKED SCAVENGING BIRDS
WITH GPS TRANSMITTERS



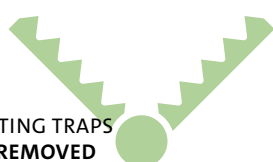
680

INVERTEBRATES RECORDED IN
THE AREAS



61

ILLEGAL HUTING TRAPS
DETECTED/REMOVED



3

REWILDING AREAS
OPEN TO VISITORS



9.1

RATING OF THE REWILDING
CENTRE BOOKINGS



101

HECTARES OF RESTORED
NATIVE FOREST



7.672

LOCAL PRODUCTS
SOLD



55

TOURIST EXPERIENCES
SOLD



32

SEMI-WILD TAUROS
IN REWILDING AREAS



3

REWILDING PRODUCTS
CO-PRODUCED WITH
COMPANIES



109

GUARD DOGS
INTEGRATED



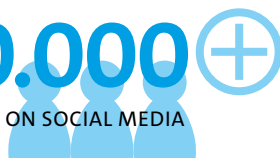
+83.000

VISITORS RECEIVED
BY THE WILD CÔA
NETWORK IN 2025



150.000

FOLLOWERS ON SOCIAL MEDIA



40

SEMI-WILD SORRAIA HORSES
IN REWILDING AREAS



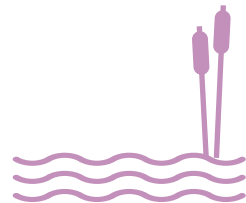
256

SUBSCRIBERS ON PATREON



53

PONDS BUILT



1.543

PARTICIPANTS IN REWILDING
PHOTO CONTESTS



376

PLANT SPECIES
REGISTERED IN
THE AREAS

116.075

REVENUE GENERATED
BY MEMBERS OF THE
WILD CÔA NETWORK



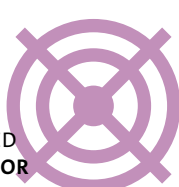
69

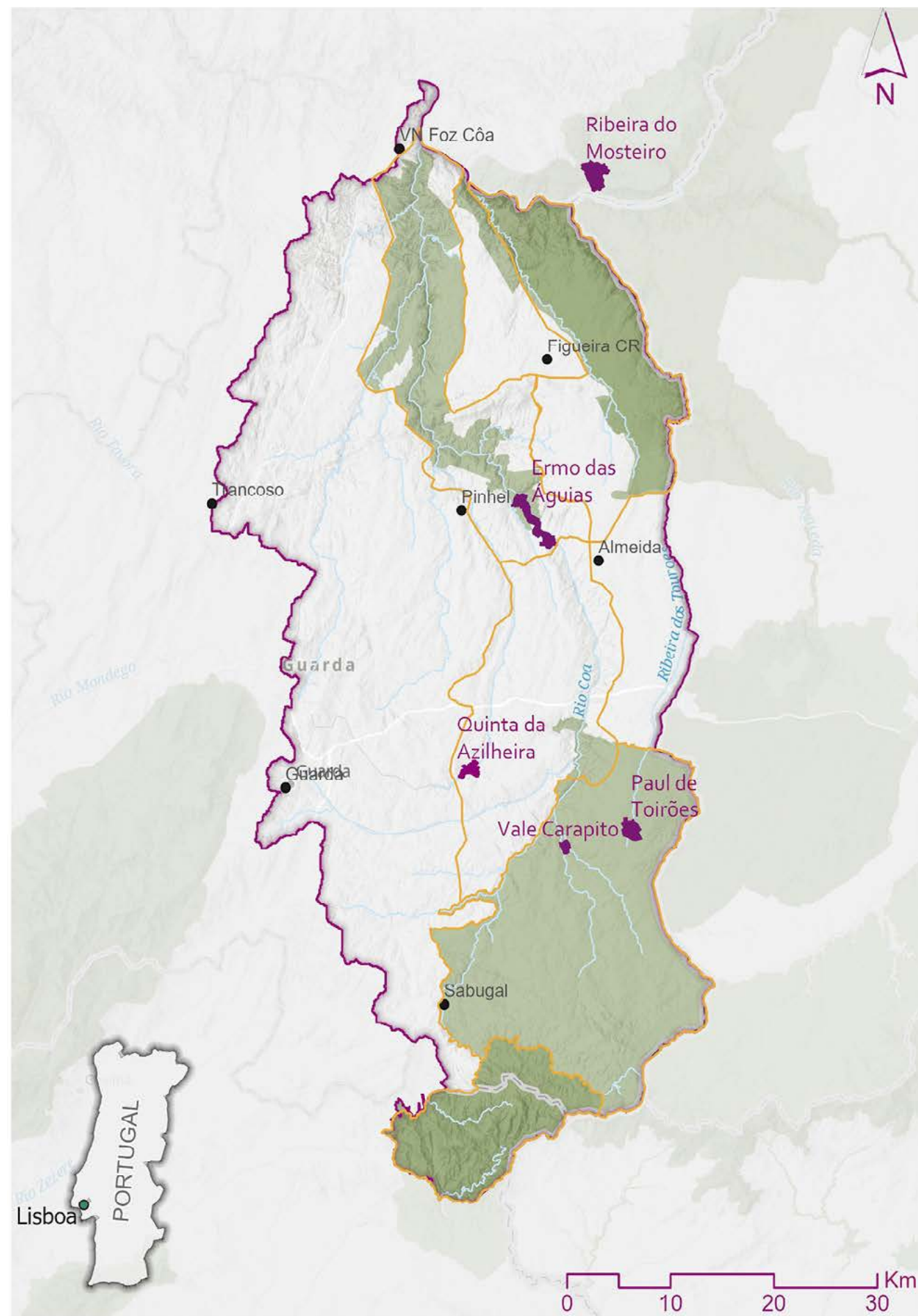
PEOPLE TRAINED
IN VISITATION



453

HECTARES CONVERTED
INTO NON-HUNTING OR
REFUGE AREAS





QUINTA DO SOL: a private initiative for rewilding

Stanley and Khaterine Reed are another couple who fell in love with the natural and wild landscape of the Greater Côa Valley. Supporters of the rewilding philosophy, they now own two different properties in the region, which they are rewilding in partnership with Rewilding Portugal, namely Quinta do Sol, in Figueira de Castelo Rodrigo.

This couple's connection to their Quinta do Sol and to Portugal began long before they took over the management of the property. Their first visit to Figueira de Castelo Rodrigo was in 2014, when they were looking for a place to spend their winter holidays associated with nature conservation projects. A contact with Rewilding Europe brought them to Portugal, an experience that would later be portrayed in an article published by Khaterine in the New York Times, highlighting a region marked by depopulation, but also by new opportunities for ecological regeneration.

It was in this context that Quinta do Sol was born as a personal project. At the time, it was a landscape with little agricultural value or potential for economic development, precisely the type of territory they were looking for. As they explain, the goal was "to find land, preferably without much agricultural or development value,

and make it better for wildlife". Quinta do Sol, like another property they own in the region, corresponded exactly to that vision. Rather than restoring the land to conventional productive use, rewilding emerged as a logical path. The owners recognise that the land would hardly be suitable for traditional models such as intensive agriculture. Instead, they chose to entrust the management of the property to Rewilding Portugal, a decision based on shared values and objectives. "Rewilding Portugal seems willing to work with us to improve the property," they say, emphasising the importance of a collaborative and longterm approach.

For these owners, the role of private individuals is central to the future of biodiversity in Portugal. In a country where much of the territory is in private hands, they believe that the restoration of ecosystems will depend largely on individual initiative, supported by

specialised organisations. "We believe that the best hope for increasing biodiversity in Portugal is through the work of private landowners, with the help of organisations such as Rewilding Portugal," they argue.

The way they view this project is clearly intergenerational. When they think about the future – 20 or 50 years from now – their ambition is simple and profound: "we would like to see more trees and wildlife." It is a vision that prioritises natural processes, ecological resilience and the gradual return of complexity to ecosystems.

They leave a personal testimony to other landowners who view rewilding with curiosity, but also with hesitation. The involvement with the land, wildlife and rural communities proved to be a transformative experience. For them, more than just a conservation project, Quinta do Sol became a source of learning and meaning, demonstrating that giving space to nature can also be a way of enriching human relations with the land.



Last year was the year we broke the record for visitors to rewilding areas: more than 800 people visited Vale Carapito, Ermo das Águias and Paul de Toirões in just one year. This number is only possible thanks to the excellent work of the three guides we currently collaborate with – Fernando Romão (Wildlife Portugal), Samuel Ribeiro (Beir'aja) and Marco Ferraz (Ambieduca).



Wild nature: ecology and territory

More than 500 years later, the beaver is back in Portugal



That moment has now arrived: the beaver is back. The preparations we have been actively calling for, however, have not.

“We have been aware of this development for some years now, and it is with great enthusiasm that we confirm this return. The beaver is a natural ally in restoring the health of our rivers and wetlands and has a key role to play in our river ecosystems,” says Pedro Prata, Team Leader at Rewilding Portugal.

An engineer at the service of our rivers

The beaver is a true ecosystem engineer. Its instinctive behaviour of building dams, digging channels and modifying riverbanks profoundly transforms the landscape, bringing diversity, water retention and life. These changes promoted by beavers have profoundly beneficial effects on biodiversity and the ecological resilience of riparian habitats.

By building dams, beavers create small wetlands, marshes and areas of standing water – habitats that are home to a huge variety of species: amphibians, aquatic insects, water birds, fish and small mammals. A real contribution to enriching biodiversity in these watercourses and their surroundings. These wetlands also act as natural water filters, retaining sediments and pollutants and reducing the speed of surface runoff, which mitigates the effects of flooding and erosion.

On the other hand, by raising the water table on riverbanks, beavers increase water retention in the soil, which is

particularly important in contexts of prolonged drought and desertification – two phenomena that are increasingly present in inland Portugal. Their structures help to store water in the territory, releasing it gradually throughout the year.

In addition, there is growing evidence that habitats created by beavers act as natural defences against wildfires by maintaining permanently wet areas that break the advance of fire and provide shelter for countless species during the most critical periods.

Key species for the rewilding movement

The concept of rewilding, has gained prominence in recent years as an innovative and systemic approach to restoring ecosystems through the return of key species, giving nature and all its components the time and space they need to evolve without human intervention. The beaver is undoubtedly one of the best European examples of this philosophy in action. Its recovery through natural expansion represents an invaluable boost for Portuguese rivers, many of which are degraded, channelled, artificialised and ecologically poor.

As Rewilding Portugal argues, the return of the beaver should not only be tolerated – it should be leveraged as a catalyst for



The return of the beaver to Portugal is a symbol of hope and change. It shows that if we give nature space and time, it responds. It is now up to us to ensure that this return is welcomed and protected.

Pedro Prata, Team Leader at Rewilding Portugal

positive ecological transformation. This is a concrete opportunity to apply, the principles of truly functional rewilding: restoring natural processes, giving nature back its leading role and creating more vibrant, resilient and biodiverse landscapes.

Coexistence will play a key role

Of course, the return of the beaver brings challenges. Their presence can sometimes impact riverside plantations or infrastructure that is poorly adapted to the natural dynamics of rivers. However, experiences in other European countries show that coexistence is possible and desirable, through simple and effective mitigation measures. Information, dialogue with local communities and technical support are essential to ensure that the return of this species is seen as good news – and not as a problem.

In Sweden, for example, beavers were reintroduced in the last century and financial compensation programmes were set up for farmers and forest owners affected by flooding caused by dams. In Germany, Beaver Managers have emerged who are able to mediate conflicts between beavers and human activities, installing water level control devices (e.g. pipes in dykes to regulate water levels without destroying dams) and promoting natural engineering solutions such as protective barriers near agricultural fields and valuable trees, practices that have also been adopted in Switzerland. Even in France, several environmental education and awareness campaigns have been carried out on the importance of beavers, and various illustrated guides have been produced on the benefits of beavers and methods for dealing with potential problems.

For this very reason, Rewilding Portugal, aware of this approach in Portugal,

decided to make this discovery public and informed the competent authorities in a timely and detailed manner, asking them to prepare for this arrival and to draw up a plan to anticipate possible conflicts with local communities, acting preventively rather than reactively and creating the conditions for a return of the species that is well prepared and based on positive coexistence. To date, this request has had no effect, and no official effort has been made in this regard. Monitoring has continued, the beaver is officially back, and we still have time to support its return in a planned manner and in harmony with what already exists. Rewilding Portugal is once again open to participating in this process.

For this very reason, the second congress dedicated to rewilding, which took place in November in Porto, devoted a large part of its agenda to the return of the beaver and its planning and preventive coexistence. We seek to lead this discussion in a responsible and timely manner, focused on constructive dialogue and anticipating potential problems and challenges.

The arrival of the beaver in Portugal is a historic and symbolic milestone for nature conservation in our country. In a context of climate crisis and biodiversity collapse, it is a sign of hope and resilience for wildlife. But it is also a call to action: to protect riparian habitats, restore ecological corridors, and support the return of species that are missing from our ecosystems.

Portugal now has a unique opportunity to write a new chapter in its relationship with nature. The beaver has already done its part and arrived on our territory. It is up to us to continue.



FIRST PERSON ACCOUNTS:

André Couto and Pedro Ribeiro

The two Rewilding Officers from Rewilding Portugal, involved in monitoring beavers and responsible for the discovery, tell us in the first person what this process was like and what the next steps are to continue monitoring this progress in the near future.

How and when was the first reliable sign of the presence of beavers in Portuguese territory detected, and when exactly did you realise that it was indeed a beaver and not another species present there?

When we detected a small fallen tree with lots of gnaw marks and lots of wood chips accumulated in the same place on the ground. No other species does that. It was in March 2025, but the water level in the Douro River was very high and conditions were not suitable for setting up camera traps.

We returned in May and saw that not only were there still fresh signs in the same place, but we also discovered other gnawed trees along the river. We set up several cameras and after a few days we had the first photos and videos of the beaver, thanks to two cameras that were flooded by the rising river level.

What monitoring methods have been used over the last few years to track the beaver's approach to the border?

We surveyed 500-metre transects along the final stretch of the Tormes, where the Spanish population was located, and the banks of the Douro, about twice a year. Both banks of these watercourses were surveyed for signs of presence, especially gnaw marks on trees. Using this method, we were able to monitor the natural expansion of beavers along the River Tormes, until we decided to devote more effort to monitoring the River

Douro. With each visit to the Tormes, we found evidence of their presence closer and closer to Portugal. Camera traps were used on the Portuguese side after we saw the first signs.

What kind of data are you still collecting now, and what do you hope to learn from continued monitoring?

We will continue to monitor the area using the same methods, focusing only on the Douro River. Now that we know that the species is present in the area, the cameras will be more important in helping us understand whether there are several individuals and whether they are established in the area. We are curious to see how they will behave in this section of the river, which offers less favourable conditions than the Tormes. We are very interested in documenting the expansion of the species in Portuguese territory. In the future, we will probably extend monitoring to the area where The Ulces River flows into the Douro, as signs of beavers have also recently been found in that river.

Is it likely that the presence of beavers in that area will continue to increase, or was it just a sporadic visit?

We still do not know whether the animal we recorded was there temporarily or whether it has in fact established a territory. However, it seems extremely likely that the species will continue to expand into the Douro, despite the existence of potential barriers (large dams) that could slow its spread, and the fact that in many places the habitat is not ideal, with very rocky banks and few trees. Ultimately, however, the young beavers from the "Spanish" families will have to find their own territory and expand into the Douro.

What does this discovery mean, personally, to each of you?

André: For me, it was a moment of great joy. It's not every day that you document the return of a species after several centuries of extinction in Portugal! It was the result of consistent and challenging efforts in the field that ultimately bore fruit. But what makes me happiest is having this important species back.

Pedro: It was one of the most memorable moments of my life as a biologist. Making the first record of a key species that had been extinct in Portugal for centuries is not something we even dream of doing when we are studying at university. The return of this species is a sign of hope for our ecosystems, which are increasingly under attack from human activity. Being at the forefront of witnessing the return of such important extinct species as the beaver is extremely gratifying and makes me want to continue working for nature conservation.

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In 2025, the Tauros returned to the Greater Côa Valley! More than a dozen individuals returned to our valley and our rewilding areas to further increase biomass consumption in the region, creating increasingly mosaic landscapes, with breaks and open areas due to their natural grazing.



© JOSÉ FONTES

MIXED HERDS: nature and herbivores in balance

In the natural world, the balance of a landscape rarely depends on a single species, even in performing similar functions. On the contrary, it arises from diversity, interaction and time. It is precisely this principle that lies at the heart of one of the main objectives of rewilding in Portugal: the return of mixed herds of large herbivores in a semi-wild environment.

Thanks to the work carried out by Rewilding Portugal, this scenario is already beginning to take shape in the Ermo das Águias rewilding area, a pioneering project in this regard. Sorraia horses and Tauros now share the same territory, recreating the natural dynamics that shaped the Portuguese landscape for centuries when large herbivores still roamed freely. This project is a first glimpse of this dynamic, but it needs time and more space for these animals to move and disperse in order to replicate the dynamic structure we want to return to in an ecosystem.

But why is it so important to bring together different species of herbivores? The answer lies in how each animal relates to its environment. Horses and cattle feed on different plants, graze in different areas and move in their own way. This complementarity creates a true natural mosaic: areas of shorter vegetation alternate with denser areas, clearings and refuges appear, and new opportunities for insects, birds, and small mammals. Where there is diversity of herbivores, there will always be more life as a result.

Just as a healthy forest is not composed of a single species of tree, open ecosystems also benefit from the presence of several large herbivores of different sizes, for example. The interactions between these species activate essential ecological processes, promoting a more effective and resilient natural restoration than any isolated artificial intervention.

In addition to the ecological benefits, mixed herds play a key role in land management. By continuously and naturally controlling vegetation, they reduce forest fuel and help to reduce the risk of fires, offering a solution with lower costs and more long-term benefits. In the future, these herds may also contribute to a healthier balance with large predators, such as the Iberian wolf, by acting as natural prey and help reduce pressure on domestic livestock. They can therefore also function as true heroes of coexistence with large predators in more rural environments.

Step by step, rewilding is restoring lost processes, wild rhythms and ecological balance to the Portuguese landscape. Because when nature returns to functioning as a whole, everyone wins - biodiversity, the territory and the communities that depend on it and still inhabit it and carry out their activities there.

Wildlife can be part of the solution to the wildfires in the Iberian Peninsula

This summer, devastating wildfires swept across Europe, with Portugal being one of the most affected countries, including the Greater Côa Valley region. As extreme weather conditions become more common, restoring natural grazing can help prevent the accumulation of flammable vegetation and reduce the severity, scale and impact of fires.

“

What we observed was that the fire advanced more slowly and erratically through the native, low vegetation, kept that way by Sorraia horses, which were only introduced two years ago... Unlike vast plantations filled with non-native tree species, such as eucalyptus or pine trees – where flames spread quickly and with great intensity – here nature has shown its ability to contain and slow down the fire.

Pedro Prata, Team Leader at Rewilding Portugal

Iberian Peninsula on fire and the case of the Greater Côa Valley

The Rewilding Portugal team experienced first-hand the damage and dangers that catastrophic wildfires can cause. In August, a series of fires swept through the Greater Côa Valley region, devastating 10% of its 318,000 hectares. In the Ermo das Águias rewilding area – where several Sorraia horses and Tauros have been released – almost 300 hectares, a quarter of its total area, were affected by the flames.

However, what happened in Ermo das Águias clearly shows how natural grazing can limit the impact of fire and increase the resilience of a landscape.

Natural grazing: a proactive solution

The extreme weather that fuelled the fires in Spain and Portugal this summer has become 40 times more likely due to climate change, initial analyses suggest. These wildfires were also 30% more intense than scientists would expect in a world without climate change, according to researchers from the World Weather Attribution network. Although climate change is increasing the frequency, scale and impact of fires, it is not the only reason why forest fires in the Iberian Peninsula are getting out of control. The underlying conditions related to the fact that most fires are man-made without strong legal consequences to discourage such practices are also a critical factor.

Efforts to combat catastrophic wildfires often focus on extinguishing the flames

after they have started burning, even though prevention is much more economical. Rewilding offers a proven and proactive alternative: restoring the function of large herbivores in the wild, such as semi-wild horses and tauros, to control flammable vegetation. By creating more irregular landscapes that act as natural barriers against fires, these animals limit the spread and severity of fires when they occur, which is why they are often described as ‘grazing fire brigades’.

Historically, large wild herbivores such as aurochs, wild horses and deer played a vital role in maintaining semi-open forests throughout the Mediterranean, while species such as bison and elk shaped forests further north and east. By consuming and trampling vegetation, these animals created space for regeneration and influenced forest structure, making landscapes more resistant to fire. With many of these species now absent or restricted to small populations, this natural resilience has been greatly diminished. Before humans affected their distribution and abundance, large wild herbivores helped maintain semi-open forests across Europe, making landscapes more resistant to forest fires (bulls are being released in many European rewilding sites as substitutes for the now extinct aurochs).

A second challenge is the expansion of monoculture plantations, particularly those containing flammable and non-native species such as pine and eucalyptus. These dense, uniform plantations, which are very common throughout Europe, are highly

vulnerable to extreme heat and drought, further increasing the risk of forest fires.

Rural depopulation and the decline associated with livestock grazing represent a unique opportunity to reintroduce wildlife into European forests. As architects of ecosystems, these wild and semi-wild herbivores not only serve as natural fire brigades, but also facilitate natural regeneration, increase biodiversity and boost carbon storage.

Support for local communities

Beyond the scene at Ermo das Águias, many livestock farmers and other Rewilding Portugal partners were severely affected by the flames last summer. To enable a strong and timely response, Rewilding Portugal launched a crowdfunding campaign to finance post-fire recovery and restoration efforts in the region, raising more than €25,000 in civilian support for this cause.

The funds raised in record time were promptly used for various purposes that required urgency and a major mobilisation of the Rewilding Portugal team: provision of wheat across the landscape to feed affected wildlife, provision of water points and fruit to increase food availability, distribution of hundreds of bags of hay bales and feed to producers who needed to continue feeding domestic livestock without natural conditions to do so after the fires, direct sowing, supplementary feeding of bees and new queen bees for affected beekeepers, purchase and installation of irrigation systems consumed by the fire, etc.

With the support of these donations and other associations and entities, both financially and logistically, it was possible in just over three weeks to guarantee the necessary support to almost a hundred affected producers and businesses, ensuring their subsistence while the landscape healed and recovered from the intense passage of the flames. In addition, we have carried out several volunteer actions, bringing together more than 100 people from all over the country and abroad to replant a large production of aromatic herbs for a partner who lost everything in this wave of fires.

A demonstration of solidarity that rewilding has embraced, affirming that local people and communities are integral to the landscape. It reflects the belief that the true restoration of the ecosystem – both natural and social – lies within the people who inhabit it.

CÔA RIVER: a river is much more than a watercourse

A river is not merely a watercourse. It is a living system, in constant motion, connecting landscapes, transporting sediments, sustaining biodiversity and shaping the human cultures that have lived around it for thousands of years. To truly fulfil this role in a functional way, a river must be free. In Portugal, the vast majority of rivers are fragmented by artificial obstacles that interrupt this continuity. The Côa River is an emblematic example of this reality, but also a symbol of hope for its reversal.

The importance of free-flowing rivers

River connectivity is essential for the proper functioning of aquatic ecosystems. Barriers such as weirs, cofferdams or small dams, even when seemingly modest, have profound and cumulative impacts. They interrupt fish migration, alter natural flow regimes, retain sediments, degrade habitats and reduce the resilience of rivers to climate change.

In a Mediterranean context, marked by prolonged periods of drought and increasingly frequent extreme events, fragmented rivers are becoming less and less capable of sustaining biodiversity and ecosystem services. On the contrary, free flowing rivers tend to be more resilient: they maintain refuge areas, renew habitats, support healthy ecosystems around them and offer direct benefits to local communities.

The Côa River: nature, culture and connectivity

The Côa River occupies a unique place in this landscape, giving its name to the entire valley. It flows through the Greater Côa Valley, a region of high ecological, cultural and symbolic value. Its banks are home to one of the most important collections of outdoor rock art in the world, testimony to a deep relationship between humans and the river over thousands of years.

However, this relationship between the river and human and wild communities has been progressively weakened. Along its course, there are several obsolete structures that no longer serve any useful purpose but continue to fragment the river. These barriers interrupt the longitudinal connectivity of the Côa River, hinder the migration of native fish species, alter sediment dynamics and contribute to the degradation of aquatic habitats. In addition, by creating areas of standing water, these structures cause periodic flooding of the rock engravings, accelerating the degradation of this priceless cultural heritage.

A protocol to restore freedom to the river

In 2023, Rewilding Portugal signed a protocol with the Portuguese Environment Agency (APA) and the Côa Parque Foundation with a clear objective: to assess and enable the removal of the cofferdams from the Côa River, temporary

structures for the creation of a dam, which fortunately was never completed, but which left these structures behind, without ever having been removed. This protocol marked the beginning of an ambitious river restoration process, based on scientific evidence, institutional collaboration and community involvement, which is still awaiting approval but is expected to go ahead.

In 2024, technical and preliminary reports were presented, pointing to clear benefits from removing the structures. From an environmental perspective, restoring connectivity will allow fish migration, habitat recovery and overall improvement of the ecological functioning of the river. From a cultural perspective, it will reduce the submersion of rock engravings, contributing to their long-term preservation. Studies also show that removal is logistically feasible, although technically demanding and financially costly. It is a complex intervention, but one that is supported by solid data and a long-term vision for the territory.

Currently, the entities involved are working to identify sources of funding that will allow them to move forward to the implementation phase. The APA has reiterated its desire to see the process come to fruition, and Rewilding Portugal is committed to doing everything in its power to press for its inclusion in future State Budgets and other national and European funding lines to make it a reality in the near future.

A river with a social mandate to be restored

In parallel with the technical work, Rewilding Portugal has developed a broad public participation process in the region over the last year. Participatory sessions were held in five municipalities, involving local authorities, farmers, riverside landowners, local associations, tour operators and citizens. The results are encouraging. Local communities demonstrate a very strong emotional, cultural and identity connection to the river. The Côa is remembered as a place for leisure, childhood, contact with nature, but also as a living heritage, with various traditional uses.

At the same time, there is a widespread perception that the river is only “partially healthy”. Water pollution, degradation of riparian vegetation, fragmentation caused by barriers and loss of biodiversity

are identified as key problems. The need to restore river connectivity consistently emerges as one of the community's priorities. This undoubtedly constitutes a social mandate for the restoration of this river: the majority of participants confirm that they want the Côa River to be restored in order to improve their quality of life and enhance the value of the area, even from a tourist attraction point of view. More than 70% of respondents expressed a willingness to participate in future initiatives, and more than 80% expressed an interest in receiving more information. This willingness reveals a rare and precious context: a river that wants to flow freely again, supported by those who live with it every day.

Returning the Côa to the landscape – and the landscape to the Côa

Restoring a river is not just about removing a structure or a set of structures. It is a process that reconnects nature, culture and communities. In the case of the Côa, restoring river continuity means allowing natural processes to reshape the landscape, species to resume their cycles, and cultural heritage to be protected in a lasting way. Free-flowing rivers are essential allies in a future that is likely to be marked by water scarcity and the effects of climate change. The Côa can become a national benchmark, as a living laboratory of participatory river restoration, where science, public policy and communities work side by side.



Renewable energy and biodiversity

The green transition can only move forward with both on an equal footing

The energy transition is now an unavoidable priority on a global scale and has been identified as an urgent solution to respond to current climate challenges. In the face of climate change, dependence on fossil fuels and energy instability in an increasingly volatile world, it is natural that renewable energies should emerge as an essential solution for reducing carbon emissions and build a more resilient future with less energy dependence, even between countries.

However, as this transition progresses rapidly, and often without adequate control, driven by economic interests that command investment markets, it is becoming increasingly clear that “green” energy is not automatically sustainable energy or even green in the true sense of the word, at least not on its own. An energy transition that ignores biodiversity

risks solving one problem only to create another immediately afterwards – equally serious and, in many cases, irreversible. If combating climate change is urgent, protecting nature cannot be treated as acceptable collateral damage.

Biodiversity: the invisible basis of sustainable land management

Biodiversity sustains ecosystems and the functionality of landscapes, on which human societies also depend, as they are clearly integrated into the landscape, shaping it with their daily actions. Biodiversity regulates the climate, protects soils, ensures the availability and natural retention of water in the landscape, promotes pollination, and guarantees the resilience of territories in the face of extreme factors that are natural but aggravated by climate change. Nature has always been prepared to respond to such phenomena, before being drained of this very capacity.

The loss of biodiversity, which has been happening at an increasingly rapid pace and is often considered irreversible, is something that rewilding responds to with effective action beyond promises or cataclysmic posturing. Inaction is not only an ecological problem, but also an economic and social problem that must be addressed.

Any sustainable development strategy for a territory – including the energy transition designed for it – must therefore recognise biodiversity as a central pillar, rather than as an obstacle of legislation and limitations to be circumvented in the definition and implementation of the project. Environmental Impact Assessments are not problems, they are guarantees of the minimum conditions for the feasibility of a project. The climate crisis and the biodiversity crisis are two sides of the same coin and require integrated responses.

Green Energy: when ‘green’ comes at too high a cost

It is undeniable that renewable energies play a crucial role in reducing greenhouse gas emissions. Solar, wind and hydro energy help to reduce climate pressure on ecosystems, which in the long term can also benefit biodiversity.

However, the way in which these infrastructures are planned and then implemented on the ground makes all the difference. Large solar or wind farms can occupy thousands of hectares, fragment habitats, destroy essential ecological corridors and endanger vulnerable species. Power lines, access roads and other associated infrastructure further amplify these impacts. When the dominant criterion is only speed of implementation

or immediate energy profitability, nature becomes invisible in the decision-making process and is then considered a mere obstacle to be overcome for approval.

A concrete example of this tension occurred in 2025 with the large-scale solar energy project SOPHIA, a specific case in the Beira Baixa region, where Rewilding Portugal spoke out against its implementation, precisely because it was promoting green energy by conditioning and fragmenting all the “green” around it. Presented as a significant contribution to the energy transition, this project envisages the occupation of thousands of hectares of land in a landscape of high ecological value. The affected area includes important habitats, sensitive species and areas that are fundamental

for ecological connectivity. In this context, the project raises an essential question: can an energy solution be considered truly green when it involves the significant destruction of the biodiversity that sustains and protects the territory? Unfortunately, this case is not an isolated exception, but rather a reflection of a global challenge: the lack of effective integration between energy policies and ecological restoration.

Effective and inclusive green

For renewable energy to be truly sustainable, a more strategic and responsible approach is needed. This means investing in land-use planning based on ecological criteria, identifying areas of low biodiversity value as priorities for energy infrastructure, and excluding areas of high ecological value and high biodiversity. It also means excluding areas of ecological connectivity, ensuring that habitats and natural wildlife corridors are not fragmented.

Environmental impact assessments must also be increasingly rigorous and transparent, carried out from the early stages of projects, and ending with this perception that they are merely administrative exercises to be overcome at an early stage. Consistency is required: there are energy targets and ecological restoration targets, and achieving one cannot mean failing to meet the others.

The energy transition does not have to come at the expense of biodiversity. On the contrary, when well planned, it can strengthen the resilience of territories, enhance natural landscapes and create truly sustainable solutions. Calling projects that irreversibly compromise nature ‘green energy’ is to empty the concepts of “green” and sustainability of their meaning. The energy transition is urgent – but it cannot be blind. Without biodiversity, there is no sustainability. And without sustainability, there is certainly no future as predicted.



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The year in review

You can sleep surrounded by nature, with no human impact or contact, and find yourself immersed in a rewilded and wild area where the ecological restoration work carried out by Rewilding Portugal is already visible, and where you might even come across Sorraia horses that are shaping the landscape of this area.

Find more info here:
www.rewilding-portugal.com/pt/rewilding/wilder-camp

The best moments of the year 2025

The year 2025 was a year of good news for wildlife in Portugal and also for the work and growth of Rewilding Portugal. A year of consolidation, big news and a lot of public support. Here are ten of the best moments of the last year, milestones for a wilder and more biodiverse Portugal.

1

The European beaver returned to Portugal hundreds of years later

After centuries of absence, evidence of the presence of the European beaver (*Castor fiber*) finally emerged in Portuguese territory, following monitoring by Rewilding Portugal in the border area with Spain. The natural dispersal of this true river engineer into Portuguese territory represents a moment of hope for wilder rivers in our country in the near future.



2

The Tauros returned to the Greater Côa Valley

In August, the Tauros returned to the Greater Côa Valley. Around 15 individuals returned to the valley and our rewilding areas to increase biomass consumption in the region, creating increasingly mosaic landscapes, with breaks and open areas due to their natural grazing. After improving the existing fences to accommodate animals of this size, their return was promoted.



3

“Wilder Côa” awarded and broadcast on television

The year 2025 was important for spreading the rewilding narrative nationwide. The documentary “Côa Mais Selvagem” (Wildest Côa), directed by João Cosme, won several national and international awards at respected film festivals and was broadcast twice on free-to-air television on SIC, reaching an average audience of over one million viewers.



4

Local support for those affected by the summer wildfires

The summer of 2025 brought new challenges. Severe and intense wildfires devastated a large area of this region, even entering the Ermo das Águias rewilding area, which ended up being dominated by undergrowth, consumed by the semi-wild herbivores present in this reserve. Rewilding Portugal launched a crowdfunding campaign and secured immediate support of over €25,000 for several livestock producers, beekeepers and other partners affected by the flames, in a rapid and timely response.



5

The launch of the first rewilding beer

A special and successful partnership to close out the last year was the birth of the first Rewilding Beer, a limited edition of only 200 bottles that sold out in less than a month, with proceeds going directly to ecological restoration efforts in the Greater Côa Valley, with Tauros featured prominently on the label. The result of a strong partnership between Rewilding Portugal and Cantinho Café, in Castelo Rodrigo, a member of the Wild Côa Network.

6

The arrival of new herds of Sorraia horses

Ermo das Águias welcomed fourteen more Sorraia horses from Germany, from two different herds, which have reinforced the current contingent and brought genetic diversity to the existing population, thereby reducing the risk of inbreeding and increasing their reproduction and expansion rate. There are now more than forty of these horses living a semi-wild state in our rewilding areas along the Greater Côa Valley.



7

Biodiversity Gallery hosted the 2nd National Rewilding Symposium

The 2nd National Rewilding Symposium, with the theme “The Return of Wildlife”, held between 3 and 4 November at the Biodiversity Gallery, was a huge success, bringing together more than 2,000 online viewers and more than 100 in-person participants per day, practically filling the venue to capacity and confirming the growing public interest in rewilding and ecological restoration in Portugal.

9

32 new entrepreneurs trained in rewilding

Rewilding Portugal, as part of the management of its Wild Côa Network and training for nature tour operators involved in the LIFE LUPI LYNX project, conducted several training sessions on rewilding, nature tourism and hospitality over the last year, training thirty-two new entrepreneurs. Since 2019, 69 operators have been trained in the Greater Côa Valley region.



8

Fábio Inácio walked 8,300km for a Wilder Portugal

The rewilder at heart, Fábio Inácio walked 8,300 kilometres on foot across five continents and raised €8,817 for rewilding efforts in the Greater Côa Valley during this epic journey, which he handed over to Rewilding Portugal on the last day of his walk, where he was received at the Rewilding Centre in Vale de Madeira, alongside his family and friends. The money raised is being used to develop an innovative camera trapping system with automatic species detection.



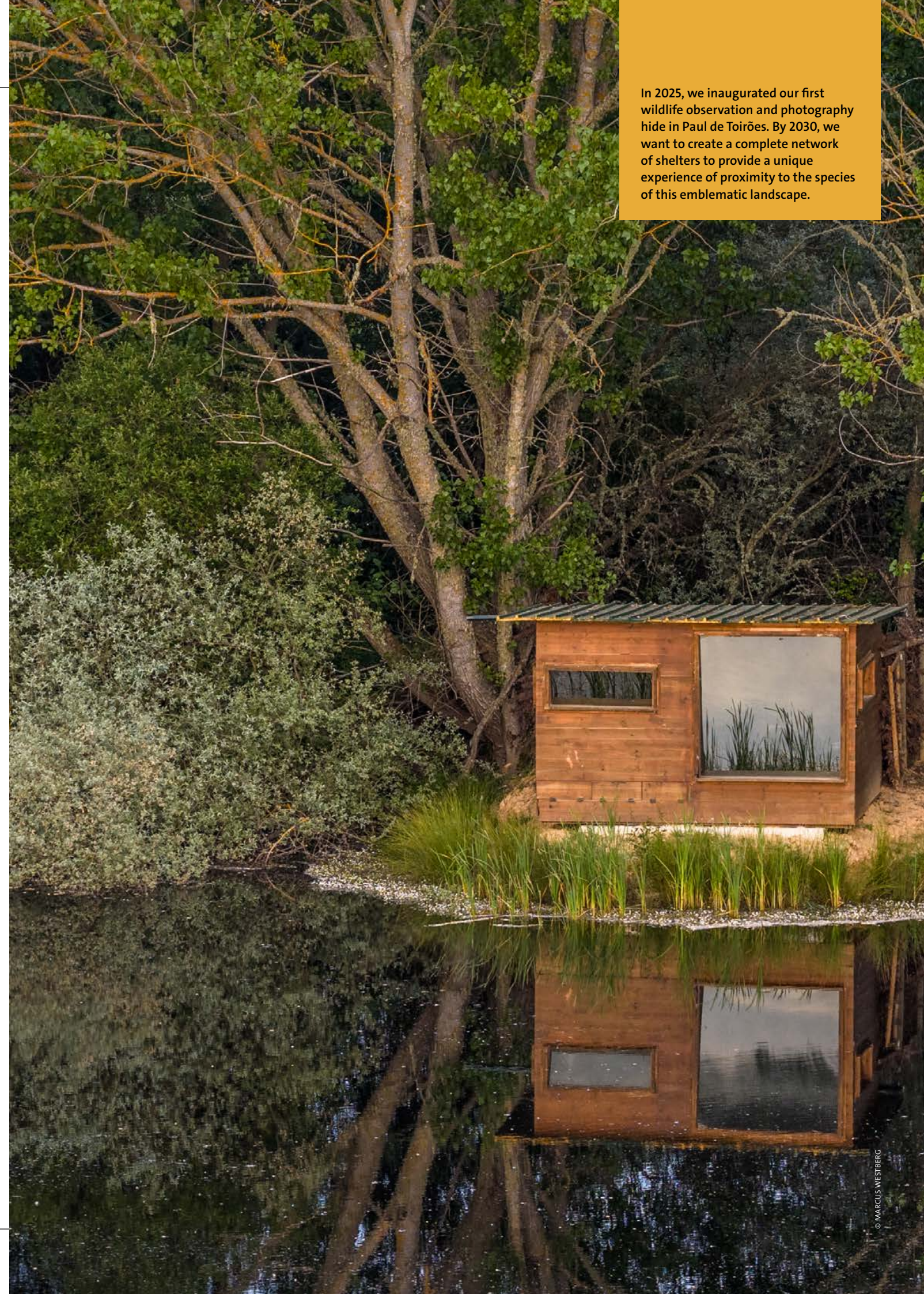
10

Gulbenkian funding supports our first environmental education programme

In 2025, the Calouste Gulbenkian Foundation announced the allocation of core funding to eight environmental non-governmental organisations and similar organisations in Portugal, including Rewilding Portugal. This support will fund our first environmental education programme, which will bring together young and old in an innovative intergenerational project to take place in several municipalities in the Greater Côa Valley this year.



In 2025, we inaugurated our first wildlife observation and photography hide in Paul de Toirões. By 2030, we want to create a complete network of shelters to provide a unique experience of proximity to the species of this emblematic landscape.





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**Building
engagement:
expanding the
message**



The 2nd National Rewilding Symposium brought together more than 2,000 online participants and a full house in Porto

On 3 and 4 November, the 2nd National Rewilding Symposium, organised by Rewilding Portugal, brought together more than 2,000 participants online and filled the Biodiversity Gallery in Porto for two intense days of sharing, reflection and debate on the future of nature in Portugal and Europe, in an event moderated by Bárbara Pais. Researchers, technicians, public decision-makers, civil society organisations and interested citizens came together to discuss how to restore ecosystems, recover species and reconcile human activities with functional natural processes.

The strong turnout for the event confirmed that rewilding is now a central theme in the debate on nature conservation, adaptation to climate change and revitalisation of rural areas. In addition to the significant participation, the symposium helped to consolidate a clear and cross-cutting message: rewilding is a structured, science-based approach that requires ecological planning, an appropriate legal framework,

economic sustainability and social involvement. Restoring nature is not an isolated act, but a long-term process that requires strategic vision, collaboration and commitment.

Rewilding: an integrated approach to biodiversity

From the very first panels, it became clear that rewilding goes far beyond the simple reintroduction of species, focusing on the recovery of functional and complete ecosystems, seeking to restore missing natural processes, which are largely brought about by missing key species, but not only. The speakers emphasised that successful projects depend on clear objectives, continuous scientific monitoring and phased, adaptive implementation capable of responding to the ecological and social characteristics of each territory.

The discussion also emphasised that rewilding involves balancing ecological, economic, social and regulatory. There

are real opportunities associated with this approach – such as nature tourism, job creation in rural areas and the enhancement of ecosystem services – but these only materialise when there is transparency, financial planning and acceptance by local communities.

One of the central themes of the symposium was clearly the role of reintroductions and population boosts in restoring these ecological processes. National and international experts showed how key species – from large herbivores to scavengers and predators – play fundamental roles in ecosystems, influencing vegetation structure, nutrient cycling, habitat connectivity and landscape resilience. The various examples presented reinforced that the success of these actions does not depend solely on the number of animals released, but on their ability to inhabit the ecosystem autonomously, in an integrated and functional manner.

Success stories at home and abroad

The symposium highlighted success stories in the Iberian Peninsula, demonstrating that the recovery of nature in this European region is possible when science, practice and collaboration intersect and work together. The recovery of the Iberian lynx, the reintroduction of the osprey in Portugal and the return of the Western swamphen to Iberian wetlands illustrated how well-structured programmes can reverse situations of extreme decline.

Important emphasis was also placed on various engineering species and resilient landscapes, with a greater focus on two specific cases of success at European level and even in Spain, which could be successfully replicated in Portugal: the beaver and the mountain goat. The European beaver, considered a true ecosystem engineer, capable of restoring rivers and wetlands, was given as an example of a key species with very positive results in places where its populations are stable and growing. It has been a species with an incredible ability to increase biodiversity and improve water retention, contributing to adaptation to climate change.

The potential return of the Ibex in a more integrated way throughout Portugal, particularly in the Serra da Estrela region, was also discussed as an ally in the restoration of mountain ecosystems, in the natural management of vegetation and in the creation of new economic opportunities linked to nature tourism to improve the economic attractiveness of this type of region. Success stories in Spain were presented, as well as the potential of nature photography as a field to be explored.

Ecological restoration in a changing climate

The last block of the symposium reinforced that restoring nature is not just a matter of planting trees and recovering forests, but also involves removing existing human pressures on the landscape, restoring ecological and river connectivity, and working



with the specificities of each territory, through nature-based solutions adapted to regional contexts.

This understanding was also emphasised by Pedro Prata, Executive Director of Rewilding Portugal, who highlighted the importance of the moment experienced during the symposium: “This meeting demonstrated that rewilding in Portugal is gaining momentum and mobilisation. Our country’s natural heritage has enormous potential to respond to current environmental challenges if we give it the space and conditions to do so, with increasingly functional and complete ecosystems. This symposium showed how science, communities and private initiative can and should move forward together in this direction, and it is important to translate this support and solid foundations into actions on the ground, nationally and increasingly structurally in the national strategy.”

The results obtained through this symposium have been compiled and published in a report specifically dedicated to this purpose, which can now be used by all entities that so wish, and we hope that they will serve as inspiration and motivation for future and short-term actions.

WHO WERE THE SPEAKERS?

Carolina Navarro, Rewilding Europe
Pedro Prata, Rewilding Portugal
Afonso Barrocal, CE3C
Leo Linnartz, ARK Rewilding
Sophie Monsarrat, Rewilding Europe
José Pereira, Palombar
Rodrigo Serra, CNR de Lince-Ibérico
Paulo Célio, CIBIO/BIOPOLIS
Ricardo Lopes, CE3C/U. Lisboa
Robert Needham, Beaver Trust
Gerhard Schwab, Southern Bavaria
Benjamin Sanz, Tracking de Mamíferos
José Granados Torres, Junta de Andalucía
João Ferreira, Fotógrafo de Natureza
Manuel Malva, Milvoz e Rewilding Portugal
Cristina Branquinho, CE3C/U. Lisboa
Nuno Bravo, APA
Helena Freitas, U. Coimbra



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WILDER CÔA: a year of recognition for the documentary

With international awards, sold-out theatres and television broadcasts to over a million people, 2025 confirmed *Wilder Côa* as a milestone in the promotion of wildlife in Portugal.

In 2025, the documentary *Côa Mais Selvagem* (*Wilder Côa*) established itself as one of Rewilding Portugal's most impactful communication tools, bringing the Greater Côa Valley to new audiences, both within and outside the country. The film, directed by João Cosme and produced by Rewilding Portugal, became a true ambassador for rewilding, consolidating national and international recognition of the work carried out by the organisation in the landscape of the Greater Côa Valley.

Throughout the year, the documentary continued its tour of cinemas, auditoriums and festivals, with more than 40 screenings and over 3,000 viewers in person. Each screening became a moment of encounter, reflection and inspiration, bringing communities, partners and the general public closer to the vision of a wilder, more functional and biodiverse territory. The enthusiasm generated around the film

confirmed the growing interest in the rewilding movement in Portugal.

On the international festival circuit, 2025 was also marked by several moments of great prestige, with five awards received, namely 2nd place in the Best Documentary category at the Xposure Photography and Film Awards in Sharjah, United Arab Emirates. Among more than 600 films from 60 countries and only nine winners, this distinction highlighted the cinematographic quality of the project and the global relevance of the message it conveys. This award joins other distinctions already won previously, bringing the total number of awards given to the film, including awards in South Africa, India, Turkey and Portugal.

The impact was further amplified when the documentary was broadcast twice on SIC during prime time, dedicated to nature content. In total, more than one

million viewers followed this journey along the River Côa, learning the endless wild landscapes of this valley, the species returning to this landscape, and the stories of coexistence that are shaping a new future for the territory. The presence on national television represented a decisive moment in expanding the project's reach, leading the message of rewilding to the whole country.

With a running time of 55 minutes, *Côa Mais Selvagem* covers the entire length of the Côa River, revealing not only the biodiversity and ecological processes in recovery, but also the people and initiatives that support and drive this transformation. By documenting five years of work in the field, the film has become a visual testimony to what can be achieved when space is given back to nature.

The success of 2025 demonstrates that rewilding is not just a conservation approach it is a mobilising narrative, capable of inspiring, engaging and generating pride. *Côa Mais Selvagem* proved that telling a story well can be as transformative as restoring a habitat. And, like the Greater Côa Valley itself, this journey is far from over.

5TH REWILDING PHOTO CONTEST:

Gonçalo Ferreira was the Rewilding Photographer of 2025

The Rewilding Photo Contest, organised by Rewilding Portugal, is one of the most prestigious nature photography competitions in Portugal, organised annually in partnership with Naturcôa and the Municipality of Sabugal. In 2025, the awards were presented of the fifth edition, with more than €2,000 to be awarded across the five categories in the competition. In addition, this was the first year that an overall prize was awarded to the best rewilding photographer of the year, with Gonçalo Ferreira winning the first edition of this new award.

The main objective of the Rewilding Photo Contest is to promote Portugal's natural heritage and its respective appreciation and protection through nature photography as a means of raising awareness among the community of the magnificent ecosystems and respective species of wild fauna and flora that we have in our country and the potential for ecological restoration of our country, believing that what can be protected and restored must first be known, and that photography has a key role in making this possible.

In 2025, the fifth edition took place, with the red deer being chosen as this year's featured species, succeeding the Egyptian vulture, and the awards ceremony was once again held part of the Naturcôa programme, which took place at the Sabugal Municipal Auditorium.

The competition had five different categories: Fauna; Flora and Fungi; Natural Landscapes; Young Photographer; and the return of the category dedicated to photographs taken in the Greater Côa Valley region, thus promoting artistic creation in the region where the organisation operates. This year saw a new record number of entries, with almost 500 photographers taking part. There were 475 in total, and the number has been growing and surpassing itself over the years.

The event will return next year, with a new species in the spotlight and maintaining these categories and formats, but with the ambition to go even further, diversifying the categories and forms of awards.



And these were the big winners:

Rewilding Photographer of the Year

Gonçalo Ferreira

Fauna Category

1st Place Ricardo Lourenço; 2nd Place
Craig Rogers; 3rd Place Gustavo
Gonçalves

Flora and Fungi Category

1st Place Pedro Lemos; 2nd Place Joana
Cerqueira; 3rd Place Ângelo Jesus

Natural Landscapes Category

1st Place Modesto Viegas; 2nd Place
Pedro Isidoro; 3rd Place Sandra Dias

Young Photographer Category

1st Place João Rodrigues; 2nd Place
Gonçalo Ferreira; 3rd Place Guilherme
Mendes

Greater Côa Valley Category

2 First Places – Gonçalo Ferreira and
Tiago Pereira

Honourable mentions were also given to the following photographers for their performance in various different categories:

Rolando Reis, Samuel Sousa, Carlos
Calretas, Nuno Moreira, Marco
Neves, Carlos Silva, José Carvalho,
Joanito, Jorge Macedo, Artur Ferrão,
Pedro Esteves, João Rodrigues,
Miguel Pires, Tiago Coelho, Gilberto
Pereira, João Ferreira, Hugo Amador,
Samuel Andrade (2), Mário Cunha,
Gui Lim, Ângelo Jesus, João Dias e
João Coutinho.



Planalto Dourado, a member of the Wild Côa Network, was severely affected by this summer's fires and lost thousands of aromatic plants and fruit trees, among various material assets linked to production. In two days, we managed to gather almost a hundred volunteers, who came to help in the process of propagating thousands of aromatic plants that will be replanted this year to replace the burnt production.

Nature for people: Strengthening ties

A year of consolidation for nature tourism in the Greater Côa Valley

Rewilding Portugal ended 2025 with very positive results in its nature tourism segment, increasingly affirming this market as a strategic pillar of its activities and for the revitalisation of the Greater Côa Valley region.

Throughout the year, 35 tourist experiences, which brought more than 300 people to the territory, generating total revenue of over €45,000 for the whole year. These figures represent historic highs until today of the offer developed in partnership with the Wild Côa Network and the attractiveness that the rewilding offer is gaining in the market.

April and July stood out as the months with the highest demand, confirming the strong trend in the spring-summer period for immersive nature experiences. The average stay was 2.3 nights, showing that visitors are looking for short but immersive experiences, focused on discovering the territory. In terms of

nationalities, 63% of participants were Portuguese, reinforcing the importance of the domestic market, with interesting demand also coming from the United Kingdom, the Netherlands, Spain and Belgium. Also, clear trends emerge at the sociodemographic level: 73.9% of visitors are over 50 years old, the typical profile of nature tourists, associated with greater financial and time availability and, of course, an interest in transformative and impactful experiences. The overwhelming majority have higher education (91.3%).

Social media leads as the main channel for attracting visitors (30.4%), followed direct recommendations (26.1%), demonstrating the power of word of mouth and

the importance of the quality of the experience. It is important to note that around half of the visitors had never been to the Greater Côa Valley before, which demonstrates the ability of rewilding to attract new audiences to the territory and generate a direct regional impact.

It is also essential to monitor visitor satisfaction with their experiences, the main objective of any tour operator. The results are extremely positive, although there is always room for to improve what is offered. 100% of visitors said they enjoyed the experience and 76.5% even gave the highest level of satisfaction. There was also consensus that the experience had the ability to create new knowledge about rewilding, which generates another round number: 100% would recommend the experience they had to others.

The most impactful moments mentioned by our visitors include the sighting of large herbivores in the wild, direct contact with rewilding areas, getting to know the partners of the Wild Côa Network and observing wildlife species that are not usually seen, as well as the strong appreciation of local communities that they feel at every moment.

The results show that nature tourism, when aligned with principles of conservation and local development, can generate positive economic, social and environmental impacts. Rewilding is also a driver of territorial regeneration and people's involvement with nature.



Rewilding Portugal has opened new local accommodation, Casa do Brigadeiro in Miuzela

Rewilding Portugal opened its second local accommodation unit in September – Casa do Brigadeiro, located in the village of Miuzela, in the municipality of Almeida.

Following the success of the Rewilding Centre in Vale de Madeira (Pinhel), which remains open and continues to offer more services and meet growing demand, this new opening has strengthened the presence of the nature conservation organisation and associated tourism in the Greater Côa Valley, increasing visitor capacity and promoting the link between nature conservation and cultural heritage.

A house with history and identity

Casa do Brigadeiro is a building of great heritage and cultural value, marked by family memories of several generations who played important roles in local history. Restored and adapted, maintaining all its original features, as well as several objects that tell the story of the property and those who lived there, it is an emblematic

building in the region, a historic house that is now gaining a new lease of life, becoming a space that reflects the mission of Rewilding Portugal: to combine nature conservation with respect for the identity and memory of the territory, without ever neglecting its relevance.

The building remains in the family's possession, who identify with the Rewilding Portugal project and its values, believing that this was the best use for this house: opening its doors to visitors, but with a strong cause behind it – ensuring that the profit generated goes towards nature conservation and restoration of the natural heritage of this region of Côa.

“This project represents a meeting point between the past and the future of the Greater Côa Valley. We want every visitor to feel that they are inhabiting an authentic space, deeply rooted in local culture, but in constant dialogue with the regenerating nature that surrounds it. Staying at Casa do Brigadeiro is to honour the legacy of this family and also contribute to a greater cause, in this case Rewilding Portugal. It is responsible tourism with a purpose,” emphasises Fernando Teixeira, Head of Communication and Enterprise at Rewilding Portugal.

A base for exploring the wildest parts of the Côa and a network of partners

With six cosy and authentic rooms, Casa do Brigadeiro offers a comfortable and intimate stay, being the ideal base for exploring two of the nearest rewilding areas: Vale Carapito and Paul de Toirões. These areas, just a 15-minute drive from the property, are the scene of biodiversity conservation, ecological restoration and natural heritage enhancement projects by Rewilding Portugal, allowing visitors to discover the wild nature and rewilding potential of this very special region. For those who want to learn about the work of Rewilding Portugal gained here a highly prepared and capable infrastructure to make this possible.

The Wild Côa Network project also plays an important role here. Wildlife Portugal and Beir'aja, for example, two companies that offer tours in these rewilding areas are now preferred contacts that can pick up guests at this accommodation directly to take them on specialised guided tours. In addition, breakfast is served directly at the accommodation by a local partner, Mercaria da Saudade. Rewilding Portugal's tourism offering is growing, but always based on these partners who share the same commitments to this territory.

An open invitation to the public

Casa do Brigadeiro is available for online bookings and aims to be a gateway for travellers, researchers and nature lovers who want to discover the Côa region in an immersive way.

Reservations can be made directly on Booking or Airbnb. Book via the link: <https://www.booking.com/hotel/pt/casa-dobrigadeiro-miuzela.pt-pt.html>



BEIR'AJA AND MERCEARIA DA SAUDADE: roots that take on new meaning alongside the Côa

There are stories that transform places. Stories made of courage and steps that are taken more with the heart than with the mind, even when everything is planned. Stories of returning to one's roots and of a deep love for nature and for places that still breathe authenticity. And these places also transform stories, and people. The story of Samuel Ribeiro and Marta Simões is one of those stories – the kind that not only change the course of a life, but also help to reshape the future of the Senhora da Póvoa Valley in Penamacor and the Greater Côa Valley itself.



Today, both are members of Rede Côa Selvagem (Wild Côa Network), with their own businesses, bringing energy, entrepreneurship and community connection to a territory whose greatest asset is its natural environment. But the journey to get here has been one of many discoveries, challenges and a growing commitment to the interior and to rewilding.

When the heart finds the territory it belongs to

It all began in 2015, when Samuel visited the Senhora da Póvoa Valley, Marta's family land, for the first time. What seemed to be just a summer visit turned into an unexpected reunion: without knowing it, Samuel had already set foot in those landscapes as a child, when he visited relatives in nearby Moita.

From then on, the valley called him back. He came for the olives, returned at different times of the year, until even the local wood called to him, and he was able to explore the region at his leisure. In 2017, the couple began to imagine a life project there – first accommodation, then other ideas, until

they reached the essential certainty: they really wanted to stay, regardless of the business they decided to pursue.

They got married in the village in 2019, at a time when long holidays outside the high season served as a trial run for the permanent move. The year 2020 brought global uncertainty, but also clarity for Samuel and Marta. With the impact of the pandemic – he out of work, she working remotely – they made the decision that had been maturing for years: to move permanently to the countryside.

Marta continued her job, balancing remote work with weekly trips to Lisbon. Samuel immersed himself in the local reality: he worked on construction sites, did odd jobs, and started teaching at a gym in Guarda. It was the necessary step before taking the big leap. In October 2020, Beir'Aja was born, a company that combined Samuel's training in sports with his passion for tourism, nature, and the stories that the region holds in every valley, every trail, and every horizon. And there are few storytellers in this territory with the eloquence that Samuel manages to put into every story he shares with those he welcomes so warmly.

Growing slowly to grow meaningfully

Between the end of 2020 and the first half of 2021, Samuel dedicated himself to building a network, creating partnerships and studying the territory as if learning a new language – with respect, curiosity and time. He worked with tourists, but also with residents. One of the most notable partnerships was with CLDS4G Penamacor Inclusivo, which allowed him to take senior physical activity classes to several villages – Meimoa, Aranhas, Aldeia do Bispo, Aldeia de João Pires, Vale da Senhora da Póvoa. He was creating community even before he created a market. A skill that he still maintains and coordinates with tourism work, having also carried out several activities from senior physical activity to villages where

Rewilding Portugal works, offering local communities opportunities like this close to home.

It was at this stage that one of the most transformative connections emerged, one that may have changed the course of events, even without us knowing it

at the time: Samuel was selected to participate in Rewilding Portugal's first Nature Guide course, at the time part of the LIFE WolFlux project, beginning a path of continuous training with Rewilding Portugal and Rewilding Europe.

Since then, he has participated in national and international training courses, specialising in biodiversity, identification species, trekking and, above all, the rewilding approach that he now embodies in an exemplary manner. The growth was slow, consistent and deeply rooted

Between challenges and rebirths, 2025 was a year of harvests

The beginning of 2024 shook certainties: a sharp downturn in business led Samuel to question everything. But the second half of the year brought the fruits of persistence – agencies he had spoken to years before finally began to contact him. And as life moves forward in echoes, September 2024 brought another flourishing: Marta opened Mercearia da Saudade, in the space that belonged to her family, restoring Vale da Senhora da Póvoa a meeting place, a place of identity and memory. A local business that is, at the same time, a gesture of love for the territory. Let's hope Marta knows this as well as we do. And it doesn't stop there: between breakfasts and catering, Marta is a connoisseur of local and traditional cuisine and is taking it beyond the region through various partnerships that are gaining increasing prominence and scale.

After years of quiet effort, 2025 proved to be an exceptional year. Beir'Aja consolidated its position, partnerships multiplied, and Samuel established himself as one of three guides qualified to accompany visitors to the rewilding areas of Rewilding Portugal – one of the faces that welcome those who come to discover the Greater Côa Valley. Self-taught, committed and deeply aligned with rewilding values, Samuel describes his recent journey: "I have more and more skills as a guide, more knowledge of flora and fauna, and also more communication tools for Rewilding and the Wild Côa Network."

And the business is constantly evolving, incorporating more and more sustainable practices and direct links to the heritage that serves as the backdrop for the visits: it has reduced the time spent in vehicles on 4x4 tours, favouring outdoor activities that have integrated moments of



The villages in this region are beginning to appreciate and valuing their natural heritage. I want to believe that this is partly because they see me 'selling' the territory and bringing people to experience it.

environmental volunteering into walking tours, such as removing invasive species or stripping acacia bark, etc. The impact of this work is already felt in the territory.

The strength to continue for those who love the land

Marta and Samuel's connection to the Valley is expressed in a visceral love, in the traditions they carry with pride and want to pass on to their son, now being raised in a rural world, they have always wanted to provide for him. "This is who I am and I don't want anything else. The Valley and Penamacor still have a world to explore," says Marta with conviction in her choice, and with her eyes set on what the future still has to bring them.

And it is precisely this inner world that she and Samuel are helping to explore today with authenticity and a firm desire to contribute to a living territory. Beir'Aja

and Mercearia da Saudade are more than just businesses. They are manifestations of a deep commitment to the interior, to biodiversity, to the people and to the traditions that make the Greater Côa Valley so special.

It is thanks to stories like Samuel and Marta's that this territory continues to grow, not en masse, but at its own pace and on its own terms, with quality and connection, because people are arriving who want to stay, who put down roots, who believe that the interior has a future, this future. And that this future is built side by side with nature.

Celebrating their journey is celebrating what rewilding also seeks: to bring life back to ecosystems and the human communities that are part of them. In communion.

WILD CÔA NETWORK: a nature-based economy that has cooperation as its greatest strength



A diverse but united network

This network, with 64 different companies, is divided into five major sectors: accommodation, local products, visitor (nature, historical, etc.), catering and DMCs/travel agencies, and has representation in eleven municipalities across this vast territory. Representation remains highest in the municipalities where Rewilding Portugal operates most directly with rewilding areas or offices, namely Guarda, Sabugal and Pinhel, but there are other municipalities with dynamic businesses joining the project and gaining increasing prominence, such as Mêda.

This is the third year that an impact and satisfaction survey has been conducted, and it is precisely from this report that all these figures and metrics come from, which are also published in a public report. At the moment, the relevance that the network is gaining in the market is clear, and this also stems from a communication potential that becomes strong and significant: Rewilding Portugal has more than 160,000 followers on its social networks and the members of the network have more than 250,000 followers in total, representing an audience of almost half a million followers who, in one way or another, have already heard about this project and can help take it to another level.

Measurable economic impact

Rewilding is attractive, especially when combined with the inherent appeal of these businesses. In 2025, members of Wild Côa Network and Rewilding Portugal welcomed more than 85,000 customers to the region. More than half of these companies reported an increase in customers compared to the previous year, confirming a trend of sustained growth.

But rewilding must be more than just attractive: it must have a positive impact on the territory where it takes place, thus creating new opportunities that unite these businesses with a more vibrant, wild and recovering nature. One of the most significant figures is the growth in turnover generated directly through the network, with more than €82,000 in turnover recorded, an increase of 138% compared to 2024. For a third of the members, this revenue would be significantly lower without belonging to the network. Even more significant: 94.3% of members believe that their business

will still be active in five years' time. Without the network, this confidence among members drops to 48.1%. This difference demonstrates the structural role of the Wild Côa Network economic viability of local businesses.

It is also a network with an impact on the ability to generate jobs and new professional opportunities for those who live in this territory. Currently, members employ 168 full-time workers, contributing directly to talent retention and economic revitalisation in the region.

Collaboration and training as central pillars

Collaboration remains one of the great assets of this network. In 2025, 70% of members collaborated directly with each other, with an average of 2 to 3 partnerships per member. In total, 59 joint events and initiatives were recorded between companies and Rewilding Portugal itself.

The most common partnerships include direct purchase of local products, creation of combined tourist packages, contracting of services between members and shared marketing. This dynamic strengthens economic circularity and creates a true nature-based business ecosystem in this region.

Training was another major focus in 2025. Since the network's inception in 2019/2020, more than a third of members have already participated in training provided by the network, with the goal of exceeding 50% by 2026. Most members recognise a strong acquisition of new skills since joining, with emphasis on: rewilding and nature observation; networking and synergies; good practices in tourism experiences; in-depth knowledge of the region.

Territorial and environmental impact

The effects of the network go beyond economic figures, and this is also one of the major concerns that sets this project apart. For this reason, more than 94% of members recognise that their businesses and their membership of the network contribute to positive coexistence with wildlife and habitat recovery.

This is reflected in local communities, with almost all members identifying an increase in local pride and the perception of the territory as a destination for nature tourism of excellence thanks to



the existence of this project. External promotion, participation in trade fairs, media presence and the production of audiovisual content have reinforced this external recognition of a region with so much to offer.

In terms of sustainability, around 40% of members implemented new practices in 2025, such as: circularity and use of local suppliers; reduction of plastics and disposables; water and energy savings; active communication of good practices to customers. Local circularity is a strategic priority, reinforcing a more resilient economic model that is less dependent on external chains.

A replicable model of naturebased economy

The Wild Côa Network demonstrates that it is possible to align ecological restoration, tourism and local development in a coherent and mutually beneficial model. The growth of nature tourism, the strengthening of local partnerships, increased turnover and confidence in the future prove that this strategy is generating concrete and multiple results.

A network that asserts itself as a community of purpose: people and nature coexisting mutually and benefiting from their interdependence.

QUINTA VALE DO TOURÃO: rewilding with roots, people and time

On the slopes of Figueira de Castelo Rodrigo, in the heart of the Greater Côa Valley, Quinta Vale do Tourão is much more than a farm, which is what makes it so special and committed to the Wild Côa Network, of which it is a member. It reflects a conscious return to the land, where nature and people rediscover their place. After a decade in France, Telma Lourenço and Xavier Mendo decided to return to their roots and transform the family farm into a living space for reconnection with the landscape, with rural heritage and with natural cycles.



The call of a valley that is regenerating itself

Telma, the third generation of a family of shepherds, felt that she could not – nor did she want to – abandon this legacy. But she wanted to reinvent it. And so, using milk from her own sheep, she created a pioneering line of handmade soaps, being the first to do so in Portugal when she started the project.

With 38 hectares of organic production, Quinta Vale do Tourão is now an example of how agrifood production can integrate the principles of rewilding. Instead of dominating the territory, here they seek to listen to it and adapt to it. Almond trees, olive groves, hazelnut trees, vineyards and a small plantation of dried flowers are cultivated according to ecological criteria, respecting the rhythms of the soil and water. The irrigation system is powered

by solar energy and activated only in the hottest months, ensuring that the plants grow with minimal interference.

Sheep wool, in turn, is used to replace industrial geotextiles, serving to retain moisture in the soil and improve fertility in a natural and circular way, taking advantage of a by-product that had been losing value and which now gains a new functionality. “We use wool from our sheep to build drains on the farm, instead of buying geotextiles – a more effective, durable and sustainable solution,” explains Telma.

At Quinta Vale do Tourão, native species are an integral part of the life and business of this young couple. The Churra Mondegueira sheep breed and the Mirandesa donkey breed, both native and endangered, are carefully preserved and

closely monitored. Many stories are shared between humans and animals, which also extend to wildlife. Wildlife is present and its coexistence with domestic animals is seen as natural. With good fences and livestock guarding dogs, conflict is avoided and coexistence is promoted. balance is possible – and that is what is practised here every day.

The couple faces this challenge with naturalness and optimism and understands that the ecosystem is made up of functional parts that must work together to be balanced.

Working with the territory, not despite it

For Telma and Xavier, being part of the Wild Côa Network is a natural extension of what they already experience in their daily lives. Networking with other producers, artisans, guides and local

“
And about
coexistence with
wildlife, it happens
naturally. Everyone
is essential and
important in the
ecosystem.”

projects reinforces the idea that the environmental and socio-economic regeneration of the territory can only be achieved together.

Sharing experiences, mutual support and the creation of collective value make this network a true social ecosystem,

as important as the ecological one. “Each of us adds something unique to the territory,” says Telma. “It is in the combination of these synergies that the true wealth of the region lies.”

Quinta Vale do Tourão does not live in isolation. On the contrary, it is open to anyone who wants to experience this way of life in an authentic and participatory way. Artisanal cheese workshops, visits to Mirandese donkeys, and the sponsorship of olive and almond trees are just some of the experiences on offer here.

The idea is simple: to share what we do, without spectacle or artifice, and to create lasting bonds between those who care for the land and those who visit it. The connection with Rewilding Portugal has reinforced this desire to welcome people. It allows us to give visibility to the farm’s work and attract an audience that values

what is being built here: a way of life where production, conservation and the natural beauty of these spaces go hand in hand.

A future built with patience

The path of Quinta Vale do Tourão is being forged step by step, always with our feet firmly planted on the ground. The future

is not a rush, but a promise – that it is possible to produce with respect, live with balance and restore the land with our own hands, a heart full of desire and a mind full of vision and planning.

Telma and Xavier know that every decision counts and believe that, if we give nature time, it will always know how to come back and give back. The earth just needs us to listen to it. And that is exactly what we do here.

The Wild Côa Network now has more than sixty members from various sectors. These are nature-based companies that coexist with wildlife, value it in their economic activity, and help to promote and publicise the Greater Côa Valley as a destination of choice for nature tourism.



A range of Altano wines developed in partnership with Rewilding Portugal to support nature conservation, making a financial contribution to rewilding projects, and featuring an innovative bag-in-tube format with a lower carbon footprint.

A partnership
that inspires...



“The Wild Cõa Network is a great example”

Victor van Dooren is a business manager at Rewilding Europe and one of the main people responsible for defining and implementing the European strategy dedicated to creating new nature-based business opportunities through rewilding on the ground. In an interview, he talks about the priorities for the coming years, the potential of the Wilder Places platform and analyses the sustained growth of the Wild Cõa Network project in Portugal.



What is Rewilding Europe’s strategy for 2030 with regard to the potential that rewilding can have on the socio-economic development of the countries where it operates?

Our strategy for 2030 is to show that rewilding is not only good for nature, it is also good for local areas and the people who live there. We want landscapes where nature’s recovery actually creates opportunities: jobs, businesses, investment and a stronger sense of identity. Our main goal is to work with teams in each country to build nature-based economies, for example around tourism and local products. If nature becomes an asset that people can benefit from, then rewilding becomes something lasting, embraced by the community.

What are the main priorities for action? What are the main economic opportunities to be explored and reinforced during this period?

Our main priority is to make nature-based economies work in practice. This means helping local businesses become stronger, more professional and better connected. The great opportunity we see in the coming years is nature-based tourism, done in a way that suits the landscape and benefits the local population. We see a clear demand for wildlife experiences and opportunities for visitors to get involved in a practical way. Strengthening the offer in the landscapes to meet this demand is essential. To help these tourism service providers reach their audience and bring together supply and demand, we have launched the Wilder Places platform. However, we are not only focused on tourism, as we are also looking for new ways of funding and partnerships related to nature, so that revenue for rewilding does not come from a single source.

Prioritising the human element in the landscape has been a differentiating factor in the rewilding approach compared to more traditional conservation. Why do this?

Because although these landscapes may be sparsely populated, they are not empty spaces: people live here and run their businesses here. Rewilding does not happen in a vacuum, it has a context. If people do not see benefits, or worse, feel excluded, it simply will not work in the long term. When local communities are involved and see new opportunities arise, rewilding becomes something they themselves embrace, support and protect. So for us, focusing on people is not a nice extra, it is essential for success.

2026 could be the year that the Wilder Places platform comes into its own. What are the prospects for the platform?

Wilder Places is at a very interesting point. The foundations have been laid, and 2026 could be the year it really proves its worth. We are already seeing an increase in interest, in terms of people visiting the platform and enquiring about experiences. The big question is whether it can attract visitors to landscapes undergoing rewilding and channel real revenue to local businesses while maintaining high quality. If so, it could be a powerful tool, not just for one place, but for several European landscapes.

This marketplace also helps us gather data on what potential visitors are looking for, which in turn allows us to work more strategically with local partners to create new offers. In terms of supply, we are currently working with local partners to increase the number and variety of multi-day trips, day experiences and stays. We are also working on a redesign to further improve the



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look and feel and integrate new features and translations into the main European languages. Our goal is to cater to a diverse audience, from international visitors looking for longer trips to regional visitors interested in coming for a day or two.

How do you view the consistent growth in turnover from naturebased businesses in the Greater Cõa Valley?

It’s very encouraging. Consistent growth shows that this is not just a short-term trend or a one-off success. It tells us that the return of wildlife, a strong narrative about the landscape and the role of nature, and coordinated local businesses can really change the local economy. This is exactly what we hope to see in rewilding landscapes.

Could the ability of non-profit organisations such as Rewilding Portugal to become increasingly financially self-sustainable through tourism translate into greater viability for this type of project?

Yes, absolutely – as long as it is done wisely. Tourism can provide stable income and reduce dependence on subsidies, which is a big step towards long-term viability. But it should not be the only source of income. When tourism is part of a broader mix, it can really strengthen organisations and enable them to reinvest directly in conservation and community work. Another consideration is finding the right balance between working with local tourism and suppliers or doing things on your own. It is not about competing. The goal should be to “grow the pie” and distribute the benefits among as many businesses as possible to develop a systemic and robust nature-based tourism economy

The Wild Cõa Network is considered a success story. How do you see the maturation of a project that brings together so many companies around rewilding?

What impresses me most is how the network has matured. It is no longer just individual companies doing their own thing, it is a group that collaborates and shares a vision and collectively benefits from rewilding. A network that works well and is rooted in the return of nature to the landscape. This kind of cooperation does not happen automatically. It demonstrates trust, good coordination and a common understanding that working together makes everyone stronger.

inally, what surprised you most about the socio-economic strategy and its implementation in the Greater Cõa Valley? Something that all other European landscapes can learn from and apply to their own situations.

What surprised me most was how quickly the initial momentum develops when people start to see real results - more visitors, more interest, more pride. The Wild Cõa Network is a great example of how bringing together like-minded businesses and people can lead to new collaborations around a common goal. For me, the big lesson for other landscapes is this: treat socio-economic development with the same seriousness as you treat ecological restoration. If we invest in people, businesses and networks from the outset, nature’s recovery has a real chance of translating into long-term prosperity.

The first Rewilding Beer has arrived on the market

2025 was also the year that Rewilding Portugal launched its first and exclusive Rewilding Beer, a limited edition of only 200 bottles in partnership with Cantinho Café, which sold out in less than a month and whose proceeds went directly to ecological restoration actions in the Greater Côa Valley and to promoting the rewilding movement in Portugal.

This beer was the result of a strong partnership between entities with the same values, operating principles and many years of connection, between Rewilding Portugal, Cantinho Café in Castelo Rodrigo, and Cerveja Vadia. A Portuguese Schwarzbier - a black beer with a smooth and pleasant profile - which appeared on the market with the slogan “Rewilding Yourself”, a direct invitation to consumers to reconnect with the natural world and to support the recovery of wilder, more functional and resilient ecosystems.

The label, created by Borboleta Design Crafts, a local artist, was inspired by the Tauros, a species of semi-wild cattle introduced into the Greater Côa Valley to functionally replace the extinct aurochs and is a symbol of strength and grandeur and one of the key species in the process of rewilding the Côa landscapes, with a growing population and an increasingly positive impact. Each bottle also carried a special and heartfelt posthumous tribute to João Paulo Sousa, creator of the name of this beer and co-owner of Cantinho Café, who left us last year, permanently celebrating his contribution to this project.

“With this special edition, we wanted everyone to be able to literally toast the return of wildlife to the Greater Côa Valley. Every bottle sold helped us to restore habitats, create ecological corridors and promote coexistence between people and wildlife,” says Fernando Teixeira, Head of Communication and Enterprise at Rewilding Portugal. On top of that, in a project where we joined forces with such a special partner as Cantinho Café, embodying an idea that Helena had for several years and made happen. Rewilding is also this: involving people, creating synergies and developing circular projects with added value,” he adds.

The first Rewilding Beer, perfect for collectors, nature enthusiasts or simply for those who want to support a wilder future, was a sales success and new editions are planned, with new ingredients that may even bring together several members of the network who produce different food products and aromatic plants that could be used in a project of this type, which is increasingly more inclusive. In Côa, we unleash our wildest side with a toast to rewilding and nature.

“

With this special edition, we wanted everyone to be able to literally toast to the return of wildlife to the Greater Côa Valley.

Each bottle sold helped us restore habitats, create ecological corridors and promote coexistence between people and wildlife.

Fernando Teixeira, Head of Communication and Enterprise at Rewilding Portugal





The number of semi-wild herbivores in rewilding areas continues to increase in the Greater Côa Valley. This population plays a fundamental role in the landscape, shaping it and creating natural breaks, which keep vegetation lower and more controlled, serving as fire prevention brigades.

Closing and final message

How to support the work of Rewilding Portugal

There are many ways to support the work of Rewilding Portugal, and all of them help to give more space back to nature in Portugal and make our country a wilder and more biodiverse place.

One of the most direct ways is to visit the Greater Côa Valley and our rewilding areas through the members of the Wild Côa Network who operate here or directly with us and with the various options available on our website. By choosing these experiences, you are not only experiencing the territory in an authentic way, but also actively contributing to the conservation of the region: part of the value of the activities goes directly to Rewilding Portugal and to the maintenance and expansion of these projects in the field.

Supporting the Wild Côa Network is also, in itself, a powerful gesture at your disposal. By enjoying its services and products, you are strengthening a network of local, nature-based businesses that believe in a wilder, more resilient and lively future for the territory and which have been directly leveraging and supporting the work of Rewilding Portugal in this region.

We currently manage two accommodation units where you can stay if you visit this region: the Rewilding Centre (Vale de Madeira, Pinhel) and Casa do Brigadeiro (Miuzela, Almeida). This is a simple and effective way to support our work if you are passing through the Greater Côa Valley. Whenever you need to stay here, choose to stay with us. By doing so, you will be contributing directly to the financing of our actions and will also have the opportunity to explore various rewilding areas, right on the doorstep of these accommodations.

If you would like to support us on a regular basis, Rewilding Portugal is also on Patreon. With a small monthly contribution, you will become part of our closest community and have access to exclusive content about our work in the field. **The subscription can be cancelled at any time. Join us on Patreon at: www.patreon.com/rewildingportugal**

Supporting Rewilding Portugal means choosing a future where nature has space to return and thrive in our country.

For companies seeking to integrate nature into their Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) strategies, there are several opportunities for collaboration with real impact, such as:

- Financing the acquisition of land dedicated to ecological restoration managed by Rewilding Portugal;
- Purchasing carbon credits and/or biodiversity credits, which we plan to launch on the market soon;
- Purchasing biomass units on our website to support work with semi-wild herbivores in natural grazing;
- Providing your teams with immersive experiences through our dedicated packages - team building programmes in nature, tailored to your company;
- Offer corporate gift baskets with local and nature-based products;
- Support the strategic expansion of rewilding in Portugal.



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Local communities are fundamental to the success of rewilding on the ground. They are also guardians of the landscape and local wildlife, and involving them in the project has been key to ensuring better coexistence with the nature that surrounds them.



Partnerships

Funders



Strategic partners



Project partners



Others



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